

Week 6 – Hitler's ascent to the Chancellorship:

Source 1 – A cartoon published shortly after Adolf Hitler became Chancellor.



THE TEMPORARY TRIANGLE.

VON HINDENBURG AND VON PAPPEN (together)—

"FOR HE'S A JOLLY GOOD FELLOW,
FOR HE'S A JOLLY GOOD FELLOW,
FOR HE'S A JOLLY GOOD FE-EL-LAW,
(Aside: "Confound him!")
AND SO SAY BOTH OF US!"

1. Explain the purpose of Source 1.

Source 1 was made to make a satirical comment about Adolf Hitler's appointment as Chancellor of Germany and to criticize the arrangement that led to this. The cartoon appears to have been made to depict Hitler as slightly buffoonish and Franz von Papen and Paul von Hindenburg as schemers who are the real reason Hitler has been elevated to Chancellor. Essentially, the cartoon was produced to state that Hitler was appointed Chancellor thanks to Hindenburg and Papen, but that this relationship will not last.

2. Explain the historical context of Source 1.

Source 1 relates to Adolf Hitler's appointment to the Chancellorship on Jan 30, 1933, specifically the role of President Paul von Hindenburg and Franz von Papen in this process. Support for Hitler's Nazi Party had grown as the effects of the Great Depression worsened in Germany. In the elections of July 1932, the Nazis became the largest party in the Reichstag. Hitler demanded that he be appointed Chancellor, however, Hindenburg refused and offered him the vice-chancellorship which Hitler declined. In elections later in the year in November the Nazis were still the largest party, however, support for them had dropped, leaving Hitler dejected at his chances. However, in January 1933, a number of key figures including Franz von Papen and Kurt von Schleicher began negotiations with Hitler to find a way to have him appointed Chancellor. Papen and Schleicher believed they could use Hitler as a figurehead and that they would be the real leaders. Ultimately, they convinced Hindenburg and on January 30, 1933 he appointed Hitler Chancellor. Events quickly showed that Hitler was able to break free from their control and establish a dictatorship.

3. Explain the message of Source 1.

The message of Source 1 is that Adolf Hitler has been appointed Chancellor thanks to the role of Paul von Hindenburg and Franz von Papen. The message is also that this arrangement will not last. The cartoon shows Hitler being held aloft by Hindenburg and von Papen, clearly implying that they are responsible for Hitler's elevation to Chancellor. The text below though clearly states 'The Temporary Triangle' and implies that this arrangement will not last. The words beneath saying 'For he's a jolly good fellow' appear to be sarcastic, questioning Papen's and Hindenburg's opinions of Hitler.